who would galvanize the team, and do it quickly. When Modi scored a hat-trick in Gujarat in December that year, Bhagwat was assured that the quest for such a forceful leader had ended.

Bhagwat hadn't always been an admirer of Modi's style of functioning. In 2006, some BJP well-wishers had met the RSS leader and expressed their concern that the party wasn't using Modi effectively. Bhagwat heard them out and then expressed his reservations. 'The problem with Modi is that he argues all the time and you can never win an argument with him. Besides, once he becomes a national leader, he will want to be the sarsanghchalak next!'

That was then. Now, though, the situation was different. The BJP was in a crisis, Modi was just the man the party needed. A meeting was held in Nagpur in April 2013 where Modi was present along with the entire RSS hierarchy, including Bhaiyyaji Joshi and Suresh Soni, both key point persons for the Sangh in Delhi. The message was unambiguous—the Sangh would fully back Modi for prime ministership. There was no time to waste in organizing and mobilizing. As someone who had attended an RSS *shakha* at the age of eight, Modi knew the Sangh's commitment to the cause was complete. In the months ahead, RSS cadres would play an important role in door-to-door campaigns, especially in north India.

In November 2013, I got a chance to have a long and candid conversation with Bhagwat at Hedgewar Bhavan, the RSS headquarters in Nagpur. The meeting was organized by Nagpur's vibrant Rotarians. I had been putting off a visit for two years to address them. Finally I agreed, provided they arranged a meeting for me with the RSS chief, which they dutifully managed.

In a small room with limited furniture, and over chai, *chiwda* and *peda*s (most RSS leaders, I find, have a noticeable sweet tooth), we discussed the emerging political situation. I asked Bhagwat why the RSS, which claimed to be against a personality cult in politics, had chosen to put all its eggs in the Modi basket. 'It is not the RSS, it is the BJP workers and the people of the country who want a strong leader. It is the people who want Modi—why should we deny them what they desire,' was his response.